

IR I: Realism (AUW)

Political Science — Master Notes · by Jakob V. Stangel

Required reading: PG = Goldstein & Pevehouse, *International Relations* — ch. 1 (*The Globalization of International Relations*) + ch. 2 (*Realist Theories*). · Lecturer: Ayça Uygur Wessel.

Theme of the lecture: first, *what is International Relations* and why we need **theories** to explain it (the field, key actors, **sovereignty**, **levels of analysis**, the **collective-goods problem**). Then the field's oldest and most influential theory: **realism** — how, in a world with no world government, states end up in **competition** for **power** and **security**.

★ **The heart of the lecture:** a theory is *an explanation of patterns* in world politics (what happened → why). Realism's answer runs in one chain: because the international system is **anarchic** (no sovereign above states), states can't trust each other, so they must **self-help**, which means watching **relative power** — and that breeds **competition**, alliances, and war. States are treated as **unitary, rational actors** pursuing the **national interest defined as power**. *Realism isn't "war is good" — it's "given anarchy, this is the logic states are trapped in."*

The red thread. Everything hangs on one word: **anarchy** — *not chaos*, just "**no world police**." Ask of any event: *how does the absence of an enforcer above states drive this?* Trust becomes risky → survival can't be outsourced → power (especially **material/military**) is the currency → and because one state's gain can shift the balance, even **cooperation** is viewed through the lens of **relative** advantage.

Key concepts / "modes" to use

- **Theory** (explains patterns) · **levels of analysis** (individual / domestic / interstate / global).
- **Collective-goods problem** & its three solutions: **dominance** · **reciprocity** · **identity**.
- **State** · **sovereignty** · **anarchy** · **non-state actors** (IGOs, NGOs, MNCs).
- **Realism** — **unitary** + **rational actor**; **national interest = power**; classical vs structural vs offensive vs neoclassical.
- **Self-help** · **power** (capability vs influence; hard/soft) · **relative vs absolute gains** · **security dilemma**.
- **Balance of power** · **balancing** (internal/external) · **polarity** (uni/bi/multi) · **hegemony** & hegemonic stability.
- **Alliances** (NATO) · **deterrence/compellence** · the **Prisoner's Dilemma**.

A. Introducing International Relations (PG ch. 1 — the set-up)

What IR is — and why we need theory

Core: IR = the relationships among the world's governments, tangled up with other actors (UN, corporations, individuals), other relationships (economics, culture), and history/geography. We need **theories** because facts don't explain themselves — a theory turns "*what happened*" into "*why*."

- *In plain terms:* a theory is a **pair of glasses**. Realism and liberalism look at the *same* events (a war, an alliance, a trade deal) and each highlights different causes. A good theory gives you **clear assumptions** (e.g. realism assumes states are **rational**) and a **shared vocabulary**.
- IR is a **subfield of political science**; its two big halves are **international security** (war & peace) and **international political economy (IPE)** (trade, money, North–South relations).

The collective-goods problem — the core puzzle of IR

Core: how can a group (of states) serve its **collective interest** when each member is tempted to put its **own** interest first? Everyone benefits from a **collective good** (clean climate, a strong alliance) *whether or not they help pay* — so each is tempted to **free-ride**, and if too many do, the good collapses.

- *In plain terms:* it's the **group-project problem** at world scale — everyone wants the good grade, nobody wants to do the work. Domestically a **government** forces contributions (taxes); internationally there's **no world government**, so the problem is especially hard.
- **Three ways to solve it** (recurring across the whole course):

Solution	How it works	<i>In plain terms</i>	Upside / Downside
Dominance	a power hierarchy imposes order top-down (a "government without a government")	<i>someone's the boss — obey those above you</i>	order & stability / oppression & resentment
Reciprocity	tit-for-tat — reward cooperation, punish cheating	<i>I'll help you if you help me; I'll hit back if you cheat</i>	robust, self-enforcing / downward spirals, hard accounting
Identity	a shared sense of "we" makes members sacrifice for the group	<i>we're family, so I give without keeping score</i>	deep cooperation / can demonise an out-group

Examples: nuclear non-proliferation runs on all three — **dominance** (the UNSC "big five" keep the bomb), **reciprocity** (the NPT bargain: you stay non-nuclear, we disarm), **identity** (Sweden/Japan chose *not* to build one). **Realism is built on the dominance principle.**

Actors — states and non-state actors

Core: the lead actors are **states** — a **state** = "*an inhabited territory controlled by a government that exercises sovereignty*." But the stage is crowded with **non-state (transnational) actors**.

- **State** = territory + government + **sovereignty** (answers to no higher authority) + **recognition** by others. Careful: *state* ≠ *nation* (a shared identity) ≠ *country*. A **nation-state** is one where the population shares a national identity — the modern state system is only **~500 years old** (before: empires, city-states, fiefs).
- **Non-state actors** (Table 1.2):

Type	Members are...	Examples
IGOs (intergovernmental orgs)	national governments	UN, NATO, WTO, EU
NGOs (non-governmental orgs)	individuals & groups	Amnesty, Red Cross, Greenpeace
MNCs (multinational corporations)	firms across borders	ExxonMobil, Toyota, Walmart
Others	individuals, cities, networks	Bono, al-Qaeda, Iraqi Kurdistan

(There are >50,000 NGOs and ~5,000 IGOs; there were 193 UN members in 2018.)

Sovereignty & anarchy

Core: **sovereignty** = a state's right to do as it likes **inside** its own borders (the **norm of non-interference**), and it's the flip side of **anarchy** — "*not chaos, but the lack of a central government that can enforce rules.*"

- *In plain terms:* **anarchy** = "**no world police.**" No one stands above states to force them to keep promises or protect them — so, realists say, each must ultimately **look after itself** and watch others' **capabilities, not their intentions.**
- **Territorial integrity** (respect borders) and **diplomatic norms** (an embassy = home soil) are strong shared **norms** — the system is far from chaotic even without a ruler.

Levels of analysis — the "zoom level" of an explanation

Core: a **level of analysis** is the *scale* at which you look for causes. The same "why" question can be answered at several levels at once — none is *the* correct one.

Level	You explain events by...	<i>In plain terms</i>	Example causes
Individual	particular people's choices/psychology	<i>the person</i>	great/"crazy" leaders, crisis decisions, assassinations
Domestic	groups <i>inside</i> a state	<i>the country's insides</i>	democracy vs dictatorship, public opinion, ethnic conflict, bureaucracies
Interstate / systemic	states interacting; the distribution of power	<i>states vs states</i>	<u>balance of power</u> , alliances, polarity, trade
Global	worldwide forces	<i>the whole planet</i>	technology, the environment, the legacy of imperialism

Tip: higher levels change **more slowly** (individuals rotate through office often; the system's structure rarely shifts). **Realism lives mostly at the interstate/systemic level.**

B. Realism — the main theory (PG ch. 2 + the deck)

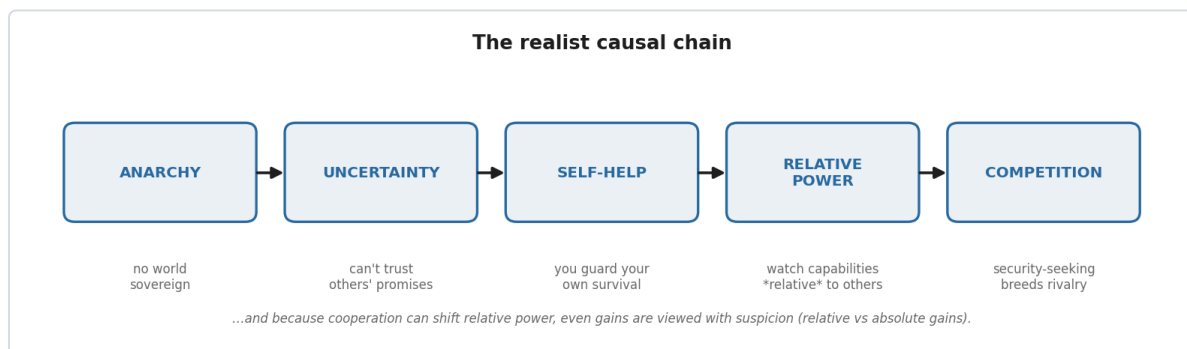
What realism is — its assumptions

Core: realism = "a broad tradition that explains IR mainly in terms of **power**." It's a **family** of theories, not one theory, but they share a few assumptions.

- **The core assumptions:** ① states are the key actors; ② each is a **unitary** actor (speaks with one voice — domestic politics is a "black box"); ③ each is a **rational** actor (defines its interests and picks the option that maximises them); ④ the system is **anarchic**; ⑤ **power politics** trumps morality, ideology and economics.
- **Rational ≠ good or moral.** A rational choice is just the best cost–benefit bet given the incentives. *If a state calculates the expected costs of **not** fighting exceed those of fighting, war can be rational.*
- **Realism vs idealism/liberalism:** where idealists see human nature as basically good and the system as a *community* that can cooperate, realists see it as **selfish** and the system as **anarchy** — and accuse idealists of studying the world as it *ought* to be, not as it is.
- **The lineage:** Thucydides ("the strong do what they can, the weak suffer what they must") • Machiavelli (expedient power) • Hobbes (the anarchic "state of nature" — cf. Hobbes in PET Module 2) • Morgenthau (modern classical realism: *national interest defined as power*).

★ The realist causal chain — the argument in one line

Core: this is the spine of the whole lecture. **Anarchy → uncertainty → self-help → attention to relative power → competition.**



How to read it (the causal chain). Walk it one link at a time: **anarchy** (no world sovereign) means a state **can't trust** others to keep promises → **uncertainty**; if no one guarantees your survival you must **self-help** (arm, ally); **self-help** means constantly judging your **capabilities relative to others**; and everyone doing this at once produces **competition**. *A worked link (deck):* "Anarchy creates uncertainty because a state can't trust another to keep its word — e.g. **Denmark–US** under Trump's Greenland threats, which pushed DK to boost conscription and Nordic military ties even though both are NATO allies."

- **Self-help ≠ 'never cooperate'.** States *do* cooperate — but always with one eye on how the deal shifts the balance.

Power — the currency of realism

Core: power = "the ability to influence others' behaviour." For realists it's mostly **material / hard power** (Lukes' 1st face — see PS Lecture 1), and it's **relational**: *how capable am I relative to you?*

- **Two ways to think about power:**

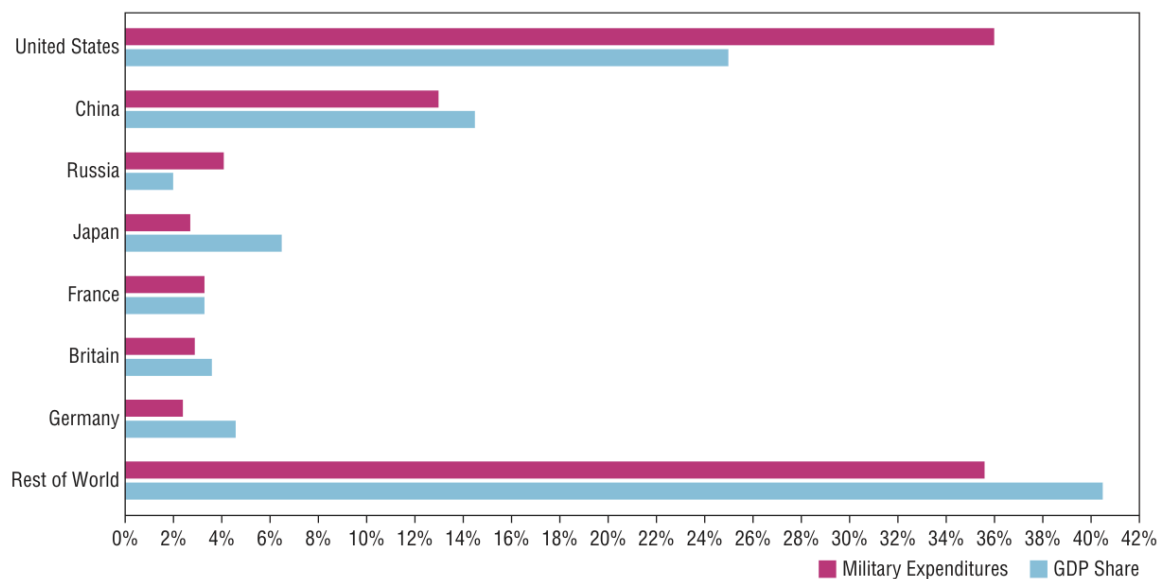
- **Power as influence** = getting another to do what it *wouldn't otherwise* do (but this is circular — we rarely know the "otherwise").
- **Power as capability** = the *resources* behind influence — easier to measure. **Best single yardstick** = **total GDP** (bundles size, wealth, technology).
- ★ **Elements of power (capabilities) — the sub-concepts.** Power-as-capability is a **bundle of resources**, and the textbook sorts them two ways: by **time horizon** (long- vs short-term) and by **tangibility** (material vs non-material).

Time horizon	Tangible (material)	Intangible (non-material)
Long-term — change slowly; <i>who will be powerful</i>	total GDP · population · territory · geography · natural resources	political culture · patriotism · education of the population · science/technology base · credibility / reputation (keeping its word) · power of ideas / soft power
Short-term — influence <i>now</i>	military forces (size, composition, preparedness — the realist's #1) · military-industrial capacity (make weapons fast) · quality of the bureaucracy	legitimacy & support from constituents/allies · loyalty of the army & politicians to the leader

- **Best single yardstick** = **total GDP** (bundles size + wealth + technology) — but only a *rough* estimator.
- **Fungibility** = how far one element **converts into** another. **Money is the most fungible** (it buys the rest); realists treat **military force** as the most important short-term element and rate the others by how fungible they are **into** military power.
- **Geopolitics** = using **geography** as power — "*location, location, location*": bases near a rival, control of **trade routes & key resources** (oil pipelines in Central Asia; new **Arctic** shipping routes as the ice melts).
- ★ **Long-term beats short-term (worked example): Pearl Harbor (1941)** — Japan had the short-term **military** edge and overran the Pacific, but the US's greater **long-term** power resources (economic potential) let it build up and **overwhelm** Japan. (*Capabilities aren't just what you have now, but what you can generate.*)
- ★ **Relative vs absolute gains (the exam favourite).** A liberal asks "*do I gain?*" (**absolute**). A realist asks "*do I gain more than my rival?*" (**relative**) — because today's cooperation can fund tomorrow's threat. (*Deck exercise: if a deal gives you +10 but your rival +20, a realist may refuse — the rival's larger gain shifts the future balance.*) Examples: US–USSR nuclear parity; US–China tech race.

Figure 2.3 Great Power Shares of World GDP, 2017, and Military Expenditures, 2016

Data Sources: World Bank Development Indicators, 2017; SIPRI Yearbook, 2016.



How to read it (great-power capabilities). Two bars per country — **GDP share** (blue) and **military-spending share** (magenta). The realist reads it as the **distribution of material power**: the **US** leads on *both*, **China** is a clear second, and the other five trail — a snapshot of who can bring what to bear. (This is "power as capability" made concrete.)

| The security dilemma — why arming backfires

Core: security dilemma = *when a state arms to feel safer, it makes others feel less safe, so they arm too — and everyone ends up less secure.* A direct product of anarchy, and the engine of **arms races**.

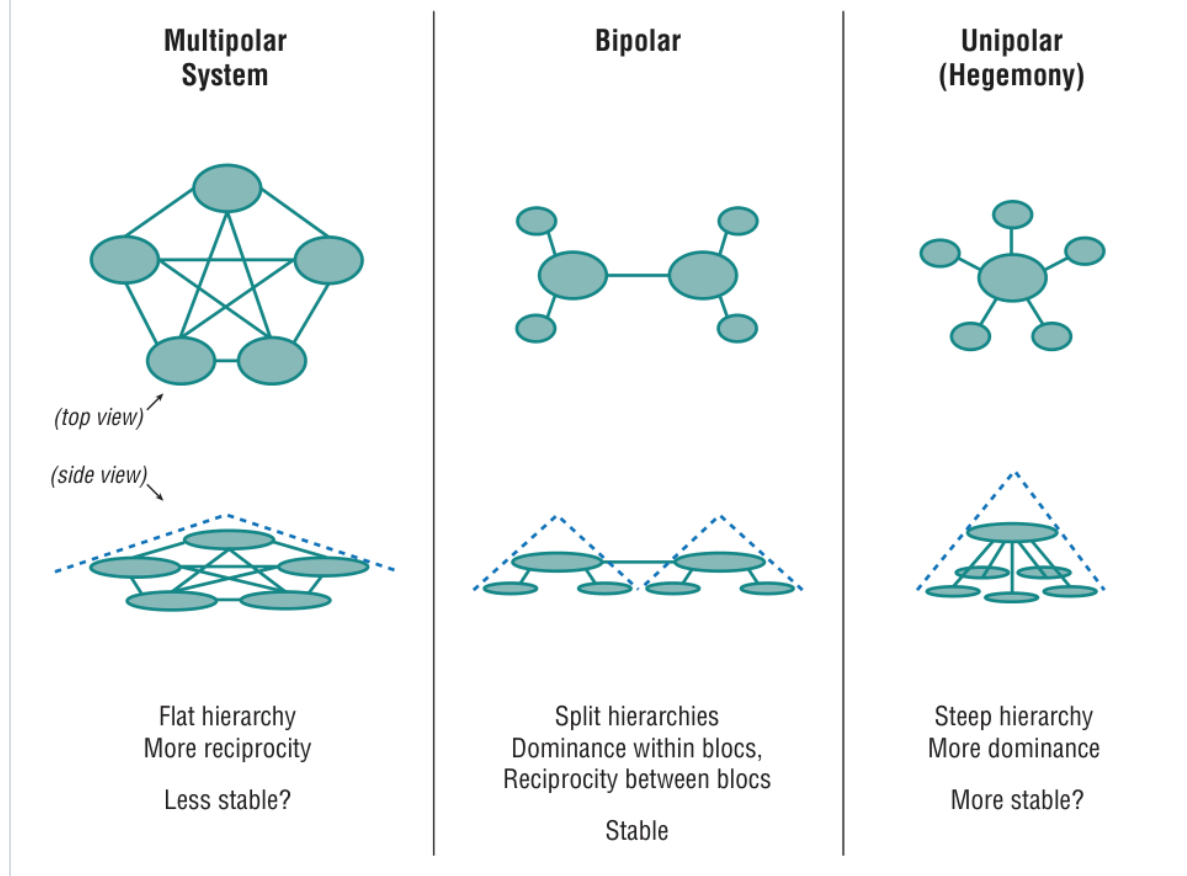
- *In plain terms*: you buy a gun for self-defence; your neighbour sees it, feels threatened, buys two; now you're both more armed and **no safer**. Realists think it's **unsolvable** under anarchy; liberals think institutions can ease it.

| Balance of power, balancing & polarity

Core: balance of power = a distribution in which **no single state can dominate** — because when power concentrates, others have an incentive to **counter** it. It can be an **outcome**, a **process** (balancing), or a **strategy**.

- **How states balance: internal balancing** (build up *your own* capabilities) vs **external balancing** (form **alliances**). A **balancer** throws its weight against whoever is strongest (Britain in Europe for centuries).
- **Balancing vs bandwagoning**: instead of balancing the strongest, small states sometimes **jump on the bandwagon** of the winner (after WWII most joined the US bloc rather than balancing it) — and states often **balance threats**, not raw power (US power was greater but less threatening than the USSR's).
- **Polarity** = how many "poles" (great-power centres) the system has — and structure shapes the choices available to states:

Figure 2.4 Power Distribution in the International System



How to read it (polarity). **Multipolar** (5–6 independent powers): a *flat* hierarchy of shifting alliances — the classic balance of power, but war-prone. **Bipolar** (two blocs, e.g. Cold War): dominance *within* each bloc, reciprocity *between* them — often judged **stable**. **Unipolar / hegemony** (one dominant state): the *steepest* hierarchy. Empirically the book reports peace is best preserved by **hegemony**, next by **bipolarity** — not by multipolar equality. (Link: **power-transition theory** says the biggest wars come when a **rising** power threatens to overtake the top state — the "Thucydides Trap," e.g. US–China.)

Hegemony & hegemonic stability

Core: a **hegemon** holds such a **preponderance of power** that it can **single-handedly set the rules** of the system (Britain in the 1800s; the US after 1945). **Hegemonic stability theory:** the system is most orderly when power is most **concentrated** — the hegemon supplies order like a stand-in government (detering aggression, underwriting free trade, providing a reserve currency).

- Why would the strongest enforce rules that help everyone? Because as the **biggest trader/producer** it gains most from an open, stable system it dominates. (Downside: weaker states may see hegemony as **infringing their sovereignty** — China uses "hegemony" as an insult.)

The realism family — four versions

Core: realism is a **family**; the versions differ on *where* the drive for power comes from and *how much* domestic politics matters.

Version	Key theorist	Where the power-drive comes from	States are...
Classical	Morgenthau (1948)	human nature + ambition; a timeless "struggle for power"	interest-maximisers
Structural / Neorealism	Waltz (1979)	the anarchic structure itself forces <u>self-help</u> (not human nature)	—
Defensive (structural)	Waltz	enough power to be safe	security maximisers → <u>balance of power forms</u>
Offensive (structural)	Mearsheimer (2001)	<i>more</i> is always safer → seek to dominate	power maximisers , never satisfied with the BoP
Neoclassical	Zakaria, Rose (1998)	structure + domestic factors (leaders, perceptions, state–society relations) as an intervening variable	—

In plain terms: **classical** = "it's in our nature"; **structural** = "it's the situation (anarchy), not our nature"; **defensive** = "grab enough to be safe"; **offensive** = "the only safe amount is *all* of it"; **neoclassical** = "structure pushes, but domestic politics filters the push."

- ★ **Offensive realism up close** — "the best defence is offence" (Mearsheimer). This is the concept behind "*you attack in order to defend yourself*." It chains straight off **capabilities**: (1) under **anarchy** you can never be **sure** of another state's **intentions** — they can hide them, and they can change overnight — so you must judge others by their **capabilities** (the realist maxim "watch capabilities, not intentions"); (2) but *any* state with the **capability** to hurt you is a **potential** threat; (3) so the *only* way to be **certain** you're safe is to be **more powerful than everyone else**. Hence offensive realists say states are **power maximisers** who **expand** — and will **strike first (pre-emption)** — not out of greed but as the *safest* route to survival. **Defensive** realists reply that grabbing *too much* power backfires: it triggers **balancing** by others (and feeds the security dilemma), so the smart move is **enough** security, not domination. (*That debate — is more power always safer, or does over-reach make you less safe? — is the whole offensive-vs-defensive-realism split.*)

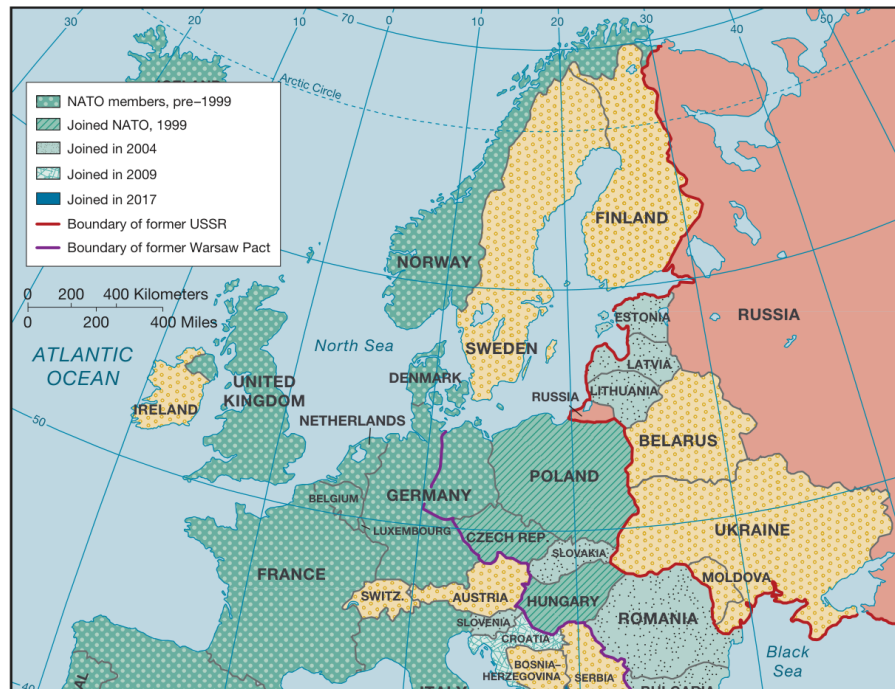
Alliances & NATO

Core: an **alliance** = a coalition of states coordinating (usually by treaty) against a **common threat**. Realists stress **fluidity** — alliances are "*marriages of convenience, not love*," made and broken on national interest (Palmerston: "*no eternal allies... only perpetual interests*"). No element of power shifts as **fast** as an alliance.

- NATO (1949)** = a US-led alliance built to **deter the USSR**; its Cold War rival was the **Warsaw Pact**. Its collective-defence heart, **Article V**, was first invoked *after 9/11* — **Europe defending the US**, the reverse of its original design. Post-Cold-War it **expanded east**:

Figure 2.7 NATO Expansion

Sources: U.S. Department of Defense.



How to read it (NATO expansion). The shading shows NATO creeping **eastward** toward Russia in waves (Poland/Czech/Hungary 1999 → the Baltics + others 2004 → ...). Realists read this as classic **security-dilemma** material: the West sees it as **securing democracies**; **Russia** sees encroachment on its borders — each side's "defensive" move looks **threatening** to the other. (**Burden-sharing** — who pays — is the recurring intra-alliance fight, e.g. Trump vs NATO.)

The Prisoner's Dilemma — why rational states fail to cooperate

Core: the **Prisoner's Dilemma (PD)** models why **rational actors**, each pursuing self-interest, all end up **worse off** than if they'd cooperated. It's realism's pessimism in a 2×2 box.

- *The story:* two prisoners are questioned separately. Each reasons "*whatever the other does, I'm better off confessing (defecting)*" — so both defect and get long sentences, when **mutual silence** (cooperation) would have been better.

Figure 2.9 Payoff Matrix in India-Pakistan PD Game

		Pakistan	
		Cooperate	Defect
India	Cooperate	(3,3)	(1,4)
	Defect	(4,1)	(2,2)

Note: First number in each group is India's payoff, second is Pakistan's. The number 4 is highest payoff, a 1 lowest.

How to read it (the PD matrix). Each cell = (*India's payoff, Pakistan's payoff*); 4 = **best**, 1 = **worst**. "Cooperate" = *don't* build the bomb; "Defect" = build it. Read India's logic: *if Pakistan builds (right column),*

$2 > 1$ so India should build; if Pakistan doesn't (left column), $4 > 3$ so India should still build. **Defecting dominates** — so both build (2, 2), even though **mutual cooperation (3, 3) is better for both**. That's the tragedy: individually rational → collectively worse. (Real world: India tested 1998, Pakistan followed within weeks.) **Deterrence** (threaten punishment so an attack never happens) and **compellence** (force someone to act) are the strategies states use to escape or manage it.

■ The cooperation puzzle — the bridge to next lecture

Core: if the system is anarchic, **why is cooperation sometimes deep and durable** (EU, WTO, NATO)?

Realist answer: institutions ultimately just **reflect the interests and power of the strongest states**.

Liberal answer (next lecture): institutions can **change the incentives** and make cooperation easier.

Cases & examples

- **Denmark-US / Greenland (Trump)** → **anarchy** → **uncertainty**: even between NATO allies, DK couldn't fully trust US respect for its sovereignty → boosted conscription & Nordic defence ties.
- **India-Pakistan nuclear race** → the **Prisoner's Dilemma** in the flesh (both defect → both nuclear, 1998).
- **US-China** → **power-transition / relative gains** — a rising power unsettling the top spot; balancing in tech, trade, the South China Sea.
- **Rise of China / balancing** → as China's capabilities grow, *others* balance it (Japan's deals with South Korea & the Philippines) — not everyone balances the US.
- **NATO expansion east** → **security dilemma** (Western "securing democracies" vs Russian "encroachment").
- **Libya 2011** → power-as-capability (NATO's ~300:1 GDP edge) *and* **unintended consequences** (weapons spilling into Mali).
- **Nuclear non-proliferation** → the **three solutions** (dominance/reciprocity/identity) working together.

Key terms

Term	Meaning
International relations (IR)	Relations among governments + their links to other actors/forces
Collective-goods problem	Serving the group interest when members are tempted to free-ride
Dominance / reciprocity / identity	The three ways to get cooperation without a world government
Sovereignty	A state's right to rule inside its own borders (non-interference)
Anarchy	No central authority above states ("no world police") — <i>not</i> chaos
Levels of analysis	The scale of explanation: individual / domestic / interstate / global
Realism	Explains IR mainly through power
Unitary / rational actor	State acts as one voice, maximising its interests (rational ≠ moral)
National interest	The state's overall interest — for realists, defined as power
Self-help	Each state must provide its own security
Power (capability vs influence)	Resources behind influence vs getting others to act differently
Relative vs absolute gains	Do I gain <i>more than my rival</i> vs do I gain at all
Security dilemma	My arming makes you insecure → you arm → both less safe
Balance of power	A distribution where no state can dominate; balancing counters the strong
Polarity	Number of great-power centres: unipolar / bipolar / multipolar
Hegemony	One state preponderant enough to set the system's rules
Alliance / NATO	Coalition vs a common threat; NATO = US-led, anti-Soviet, now expanded
Prisoner's Dilemma	Rational self-interest → both defect → both worse off than cooperating
Deterrence / compellence	Threat to stop an action vs threat to force an action

Exam pointers

- Define **anarchy** correctly (**not chaos** — no enforcer) and run the realist causal chain cold: anarchy → uncertainty → self-help → relative power → competition.
- List realism's **assumptions** (unitary + rational actor, states, anarchy, power > morality) and stress **rational ≠ good** (war can be rational).
- Explain **power** as **capability vs influence**, and nail relative vs absolute gains (the realist refuses a deal a liberal would take).
- Explain the security dilemma and use NATO expansion as the case.
- Compare polarity types and state the finding that **hegemony/bipolarity** preserve peace better than multipolarity; add **power-transition theory**.

- Place the four realisms (classical/defensive/offensive/neoclassical) and their theorists.
- Work the Prisoner's Dilemma matrix (why *defect* dominates → both worse off) and connect it to arms races & deterrence.
- Use the collective-goods problem + **dominance/reciprocity/identity** to frame *why* cooperation is hard under anarchy.

★ Fun facts & memorable details (IR I: Realism)

Sticky bits from the realism lecture.

- **Thucydides**, ~2,400 years ago: "*the strong do what they have the power to do and the weak accept what they have to accept*" — realism's oldest one-liner.
 - **Anarchy ≠ chaos**. It just means **no world police** — the system actually runs on remarkably stable **norms** (an embassy is treated as home soil; borders are respected).
 - **Rational ≠ right**: for a realist, if the expected cost of *not* fighting beats the cost of fighting, **war is the rational choice** — morality doesn't enter the calculation.
 - **NATO's Article V** (an attack on one is an attack on all) has been invoked **exactly once** — after **9/11**, with **Europe** coming to the defence of the **US**, the mirror image of why NATO was built.
 - **The relative-gains trap**: a realist may **turn down** a deal that makes them richer (+10) if it makes a rival richer still (+20) — because the *gap* is what shapes tomorrow's balance of power.
 - **Peace by inequality**: the book's counterintuitive finding — a lopsided **hegemony** (one dominant power) keeps the peace *better* than a balanced, equal, multipolar world.
 - **Bandwagoning beats balancing (sometimes)**: after WWII most states didn't gang up on the US — they **joined** it, puzzling pure balance-of-power theory.
 - **Palmerston (1848)**: "*We have no eternal allies and we have no perpetual enemies. Our interests are perpetual*" — the realist view of alliances as marriages of convenience.
-